

Theme parks and visitor attractions

Closed-season review framework

A structured framework for operators to assess guest experience, pathfinding, asset condition, accessibility and capital programme risk ahead of the next operating season.

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Purpose and scope

This framework supports operators in preparing for the next operating season. It comprises seven modules. Each may be completed independently by the relevant function, and the outputs together form a baseline for the closed-season programme.

Module	Title	Purpose	Responsible function	Page
01	Guest journey assessment	Evaluate the visit against 17 criteria from arrival to egress.	Operations	3
02	Queue experience measures	Prioritise interventions by cost category and lead time.	Operations, estates	5
03	Pathfinding and circulation	Assess how guests find, choose and follow routes.	Operations, design	6
04	Asset condition pre-assessment	Identify elements requiring professional inspection.	Estates	8
05	Accessibility pre-assessment	Screen the site against ten access criteria.	Operations, guest services	9
06	Capital project programme	Establish latest start dates from a target opening date.	Capital projects	10
07	Consultant appointment criteria	Evaluate consultants for works on an operational site.	Procurement	11

Method

Modules 01 to 03 should be completed on a peak operating day. Module 04 should be completed immediately after the season closes, to allow repairs to be specified and procured over the winter. Modules 05 to 07 may be completed at any time.

Exclusions

This framework does not constitute a safety inspection. Amusement devices are subject to inspection under the Amusement Devices Inspection Procedures Scheme (ADIPS), in accordance with HSE guidance HSG175. Module 04 is limited to buildings, structures and external works, and does not replace a professional survey.

MODULE 01

Guest journey assessment

Assess the visit on a peak operating day, following the guest route from arrival to egress.
Record the current position only.

Ref.	Criterion	Standard	Met	Observation
A · Arrival				
A1	Wayfinding from the approach road and car park leads directly to the entrance.	No backtracking. Consistent terminology on all signs.	☐	
A2	The route from the car park to the entrance provides seating and shelter.	Rest points at regular intervals on longer routes.	☐	
A3	Peak entry wait time is measured and communicated to guests.	Measured on peak days. Displayed at the car park or entrance.	☐	
A4	Orientation on entry is immediate.	Map, clear sightline or host within the entry plaza.	☐	
B · Queues				
B1	Wait times are displayed at every principal attraction.	Accurate and updated at set intervals.	☐	
B2	The longest queues are sheltered.	Shade and weather protection across the majority of the queue length.	☐	
B3	Queue progress is visible to guests.	Progress markers or staged queue design. No concealed switchbacks.	☐	
B4	The longest waits are occupied.	Sightlines, interpretation or pre-show content.	☐	
C · Food and beverage				
C1	Peak demand is distributed across outlets.	No outlet at capacity while others are under-used.	☐	
C2	Pricing is transparent before guests queue.	Menu and family offer visible at the point of decision.	☐	
C3	Covered seating adjoins each principal outlet.	Sufficient for peak demand.	☐	

Ref.	Criterion	Standard	Met	Observation
D · Rest and amenities				
D1	Shaded seating is provided on principal routes.	At regular intervals on every main route.	☐	
D2	Toilets and baby change are signed from every zone.	Consistent with the site map.	☐	
D3	A quiet space is provided.	Signed on site and referenced in published access information.	☐	
E · Afternoon and egress				
E1	Programmed content sustains dwell time after 15:00.	Shows, events or activities scheduled into the late afternoon.	☐	
E2	The egress route is free of pinch points.	Exit not routed through congested retail.	☐	
E3	Egress is managed.	Staff presence at the gate at close. Car park egress managed at peak.	☐	

Interpretation

Result, by section	Recommended response
All criteria met	No action required.
One criterion not met	Operational review within the current month.
Two or more not met	Include in the closed-season design review. The cause is frequently spatial.

Assessed by	Date and time
Attendance and weather	Priority actions

MODULE 02

Queue experience measures

Perceived waiting time is influenced by uncertainty, comfort and occupation as much as by actual duration. The measures below are ordered by cost and lead time. The first three may be implemented within the current season.

Adopted Measure	Cost category	Lead time	Responsible function
☐ Wait-time displays at queue entrances	Operating expenditure	Weeks	Operations
☐ Wait markers within the queue line	Operating expenditure	Weeks	Operations
☐ Re-scheduling of shows to redistribute peak demand	None	Immediate	Entertainment
☐ Seating or lean rails at switchbacks	Minor capital	Closed season	Estates
☐ Shelter over the longest exposed section	Minor capital	Closed season	Estates, design
☐ Sightlines from the queue to the attraction	Minor capital	Closed season	Design
☐ Single-rider or virtual queue options, where the ride permits	Varies	One season	Operations, ride supplier
☐ Queue interpretation, pre-show or theming	Capital	One or two closed seasons	Design, theming

Baseline measurement

Record actual and perceived wait times at the principal attraction at 11:00, 13:00 and 15:00 on a peak day, using a short guest survey for perceived time. Repeat after each intervention to establish its effect.

Cost categories

Operating expenditure: within existing operating budgets. **Minor capital:** a discrete capital item. **Capital:** a project requiring design and, potentially, planning permission.

MODULE 03

Pathfinding and circulation

Pathfinding describes how guests find, choose and follow routes through the site. Where it fails, guests backtrack, crowd junctions and miss attractions, food and retail. Assess on a peak day, from the perspective of a first-time visitor.

Ref.	Criterion	Standard	Met	Observation
P · Orientation				
P1	A site map is available at the entrance, online and at principal decision points.	Consistent across print, digital and on-site signage.	☐	
P2	Zones have clear and distinct names.	Names used identically on signs, maps, the app and by staff.	☐	
P3	Landmarks are visible from principal routes.	Guests can orient themselves by a visible feature.	☐	
Q · Decision points				
Q1	Every principal junction carries directional signage.	Visible on approach, not only at the junction itself.	☐	
Q2	Destinations are listed in a consistent order and hierarchy.	Toilets, exits and first aid shown on every sign.	☐	
Q3	Walking times are given to major destinations.	Expressed in minutes rather than distance.	☐	
R · Circulation				
R1	Principal routes form a circuit without dead ends.	Guests can return to the entrance without retracing their route.	☐	
R2	Route widths accommodate peak flows at pinch points.	No sustained crowding at junctions, queue entrances or show exits.	☐	
R3	Ride and show exits disperse without obstructing routes.	Exit flows directed away from queue entrances.	☐	

Ref.	Criterion	Standard	Met	Observation
S · Inclusive pathfinding				
S1	Step-free routes are marked on the map and on site.	Continuous from the car park to every accessible attraction.	☐	
S2	Signage is legible.	Adequate contrast, size and mounting height, including for seated users.	☐	
S3	Meeting points are designated and signed.	Used by staff when reuniting separated groups.	☐	
T · Digital				
T1	The app or online map reflects current openings and closures.	Updated on the day.	☐	
T2	Wait times and show times are available at decision points.	On screens at junctions or through the app.	☐	

Junction observation

Select the three busiest junctions. At each, observe for 15 minutes at peak and record the number of guests who hesitate, consult a map, ask staff or turn back.

Junction	Hesitate	Consult map	Ask staff	Turn back	Total

Interpretation

Two or more criteria not met in any section indicates a pathfinding review within the closed-season programme. A junction with consistently high counts should be reviewed for signage, sightlines and route width before any new signage is procured.

Relationship to other modules

Findings should be read with Module 01 (guest journey) and Module 05 (accessibility). Step-free routes and signage legibility are assessed in both.

MODULE 04

Asset condition pre-assessment

A visual pre-assessment of buildings, structures and external works, to identify elements requiring professional inspection before the next operating season.

InspectedElement	Indicators	Escalation
☐ Timber structures	Decay at post bases, split members, loosened connections, standing water at joints.	Building surveyor. Structural engineer where a primary member is affected.
☐ Steel structures and balustrades	Corrosion at bases and welds, loose fixings, movement under load.	Building surveyor. Structural engineer for load-bearing elements.
☐ Themed facades and render	Cracking, debonded render, water ingress at copings and edges.	Building surveyor.
☐ Roofs and rainwater goods	Displaced coverings, blocked gutters, internal staining.	Building surveyor or roofing contractor.
☐ External surfaces	Trip hazards, heave, loose paving, ponding.	Building surveyor or landscape contractor.
☐ Drainage	Persistent standing water, silted gullies, edge erosion.	Building surveyor or drainage contractor.
☐ Signage, lighting and fixings	Loose signage, lighting failures, corroded brackets.	Estates team or electrical contractor.

Timing and recording

Complete immediately after closure. Photograph each item and reference its location on the site plan, so that repairs can be specified, priced and programmed within the closed season.

Immediate risk

Where any element presents an immediate risk, isolate the area and obtain a structural engineer's assessment before further use. Amusement devices are excluded and remain subject to ADIPS inspection.

MODULE 05

Accessibility pre-assessment

Access requirements extend to wheelchair users, families with pushchairs, older visitors and guests with sensory or neurodivergent needs. In the UK, 16.8 million people, around one in four, report a disability. Visit decisions are frequently made at group level.

Yes	No	Criterion
☐	☐	Published access information covers parking, routes, toilets, quiet spaces and the suitability of each attraction.
☐	☐	Accessible parking is located close to the entrance with a level or ramped route.
☐	☐	A staffed, step-free alternative to turnstiles is available throughout opening hours.
☐	☐	Principal routes are step-free and provide rest points.
☐	☐	Accessible toilets are provided on each principal route, and a Changing Places facility is provided or clearly signposted.
☐	☐	Queue lines are usable by wheelchair users, or an equivalent alternative is in place.
☐	☐	Food and retail counters include a lowered section.
☐	☐	Signage is legible and uses the same terminology as the site map.
☐	☐	Front-of-house staff are briefed on access arrangements.
☐	☐	Sensory information is available for each attraction.

Interpretation

Three or more criteria not met indicates that an accessibility review is likely to be of value, particularly in advance of capital works, when access provision can be incorporated at least cost.

Legal context

Service providers have a duty under the Equality Act 2010 to make reasonable adjustments for disabled people. This module is a screening tool. It is not legal advice and does not constitute a certified access audit.

Source: Department for Work and Pensions, Family Resources Survey, financial year 2023 to 2024.

MODULE 06

Capital project programme

Enter the target opening date and calculate the latest start date for each stage, working backwards. Programme time lost before the planning submission is the most difficult to recover.

Target opening date

Stage	Indicative duration	Output	Latest start
Testing and trial operation	Per ride supplier	Handover for public operation.	
Construction and installation	Per ride supplier	Subject to scope and equipment lead time.	
Tender and contract	4 to 8 weeks	Contractor appointment and contract sum.	
Technical design	8 to 16 weeks	Building regulations and tender information.	
Planning determination	8 or 13 weeks from validation	Decision on a minor or major application.	
Specialist reports	4 to 12 weeks	Noise, transport, ecology and heritage, as required.	
Pre-application advice	4 to 8 weeks	Written view of the local planning authority.	
Concept design	6 to 10 weeks	Guest journey, capacity and design direction.	
Brief and feasibility	4 to 8 weeks	Confirmed brief, site capacity and cost range.	

Planning determination

The statutory period for major applications in England is 13 weeks. In January to March 2026, 19% of major applications were determined within that period; most were determined within an extension agreed with the applicant. Programmes should allow for this.

Seasonal constraints

Certain ecological surveys can only be undertaken during defined periods of the year. Where required, they should be commissioned early, as a missed survey window can delay submission by several months.

Durations are indicative ranges and will vary by project. Planning data: Ministry of Housing, Communities and Local Government, Planning applications in England, January to March 2026.

MODULE 07

Consultant appointment criteria

Criteria for evaluating design consultants for works on an operational site. They apply to any appointment, including FADP Architecture.

Received	Criterion	Evidence to request
☐	Named lead	The individual who will lead the commission and attend site.
☐	Relevant experience	Evidence of work on sites that remained operational during delivery.
☐	Phasing	A phasing proposal aligned to the operating calendar.
☐	Fee basis	A fixed fee for each stage, with the basis for any variation.
☐	Deliverables	The documents to be issued at each stage.
☐	Performance measures	Measures agreed at appointment and reviewed at completion.
☐	Design responsibility	Confirmation of who holds design responsibility and whether the consultant can act as principal designer under the CDM Regulations 2015.
☐	Insurance	Certificates for professional indemnity and public liability insurance.
☐	References	Contact details for comparable previous clients.

FADP Architecture's position

Each commission is led by a director: Aun Naeem for design and masterplanning, and Fatima Shakeel for planning. Fees are fixed for each stage and confirmed in writing. The practice can act as principal designer for the design phase. Insurance certificates are provided with each proposal. The practice's completed and concept work to date spans residential, heritage, hospitality, masterplanning and industrial projects; attraction projects will be published, with the operator's consent, as they complete.

About FADP Architecture

FADP Architecture is a design practice led by two directors, providing planning, design, survey and principal designer services. For theme parks and visitor attractions, the practice works on operational sites, with every commission programmed around the operating season.

Service	Scope	Indicative duration
Guest Experience Review	Independent assessment of the visit, with prioritised actions.	3 to 5 weeks
Building and condition surveys	Measured and condition surveys with a prioritised repair schedule.	3 to 6 weeks
Accessibility review	Design review of access across the site.	3 to 6 weeks
New attractions and refurbishment	Design of attraction buildings, queues, themed areas and entrances.	By stage
Planning and masterplanning	Site masterplans and planning applications to determination.	3 to 4 months plus determination

Engagement process

1	2	3	4
Introductory call	Site visit	Site visit note	Proposal
Scope of the requirement and suitability of the practice.	A half-day visit. The fee is fixed and confirmed in writing in advance.	Issued within five working days, with a recommendation on further work.	Scope, programme, team, performance measures and fixed fee.

Enquiries. design@fadp.co.uk · fadp.co.uk/attractions · Enquiries are acknowledged by a director within one working day.